The assurance drew thunderous applause. Reuters described the hype around the launch as ‘a media circus more worthy of a pop concert or an Oscar ceremony’. The people were impressed with the product and its stylish design. They even touched the car to confirm for themselves if it was real. Tata’s dream project put India on the world map for innovation in the auto industry. When I requested Ratan to recall his most memorable day of his life, in an instant he said, ‘Amongst the happiest and most fulfilling would be the creation of the Nano.’ It was ‘because everyone said that a one lakh car was not possible, and we did that’.

‘It brought out the innovative streak in the organization,’ says Kant. The Nano was hailed as the epitome of ‘frugal engineering’ and low-cost manufacturing capabilities. Mahindra Group Chairman Anand Mahindra called the Nano ‘a shot that was heard around the world’.

But not all the fellow industrialists were so appreciative. The owner of a large two-wheeler company swore at a SIAM meeting: ‘I would fight the Nano with everything I have,’ recalls Ratan. But the reticent Ratan can be stubborn in a fight when he is convinced that he is right.

To ensure that the company stuck to the target of rolling out the car at the required volume, it was produced temporarily from Tata Motors’ existing plants in Pune and Pantnagar. In the meantime, the shift from Singur to Sanand was set in motion under Ramesh Vishwakarma, the head of manufacturing.

The Nano was launched in Mumbai on 23 March 2009. Pre-bookings opened in April. The strategy to begin the initial production at the plants in Pune and Pantnagar helped the company to stay on course for their formal launch. ‘Tata Motors began delivering the Nano in July 2009 from its Pantnagar factory in Uttarakhand state after receiving 206,703 bookings from April to June,’ *The Wall Street Journal* reported. In view of the limited production, the first ‘100,000 customers were chosen’ through a lottery system.

When the car was displayed at the Geneva Motor Show later that year, Carlos Ghosn termed Ratan a ‘visionary’. The Nano became the cynosure of everyone’s attention. It was listed in *The Guinness Book of World Records* as the ‘World’s Cheapest Car’, and won a plethora of international awards, including *The Wall Street Journal*’s Technology Innovation Award in 2008. It also bagged a gold at the prestigious Edison Awards in 2010 in the best new product segment under the transportation category.